

Working-session *synthesis*

Meeting #2 · May 19, 2026 — *the vision made tactical.*

Session date: May 19, 2026 (~4.5 hrs) **Participants:** Mario Ramos (Chairperson), Pedro Rosa (Facilitator), and committee members/elders present in the gym circle **Purpose:** Move the initiative from organic mentorship toward a defined, executable plan for the founding summer **Source note:** Reconstructed from two recordings of the same session. The longer recording captured nearly the full meeting (including the live AI working session that drafted the one-pager, committee deck, and strategy doc in real time); the shorter one covers an overlapping segment plus the closing naming conversation.

How to read this: Items are tagged as either **[Firm]** — decisions to carry into the canonical artifacts — or **[Emerging intent]** — sentiments and directions the committee is drawn to but is deliberately letting evolve, with no action attached yet.

1. Headline outcome

The session produced and validated a sharper sense of *what this is*. The group landed on a reframe everyone affirmed:

This is **family, not philanthropy**. It's a way for a community of friends and peers to collectively invest in kids in their community — the scholarship money is one important initiative, not the point.

The real product, as articulated and confirmed in the room, is three things: – Kids feel **seen and supported** by adults around them as they hit milestones. – Donors experience the **tangible joy** of watching specific kids do specific things with their contribution. – A **small trusted circle** (Mario, Munchie, Rob, Ray, Tony, others) learns together what this could become.

[Emerging intent] Importantly, "family not philanthropy" came up primarily as *emotional fuel and alignment* in the meeting — a read on how invested the committee's hearts are, and a desire to see everyone involved (committee, donors, mentors, and mentees) as family rather than as a charity. It doesn't need to drive action right now, and we shouldn't over-index on it. We'll watch whether it resurfaces in a way that carries practical impact.

2. Shared understanding the session sharpened (intent level)

The "incubator" stance. **[Firm intent]** Keep the founding year deliberately small and intimate. Mario is intentionally holding fundraising scale down to protect the learning curve — "walk before we run." This is a feature, not a limitation.

Cohort over crowd. **[Firm intent]** Go deep with a focused group (roughly 5–10) rather than wide. The founding cohort is **seven young people** — the most consistent and earnest participants who have shown up through 2026, mostly arriving by word of mouth. Selection rationale is participation and consistency, not a formal screen. As these kids age out, new consistent participants rotate in.

Presence is the work. **[Firm intent]** The point of the initiatives (games, trips, visits) is to create the everyday moments — and the "outlier" memories that stick — the same village dynamic the founders grew up with. Showing up consistently is the mechanism.

Mentor diversity as a credibility asset. **[Firm intent]** Materials should convey that the circle spans real, relatable men across walks of life — retired and current police, firefighters and first responders, union tradesmen, railroad workers, tech and real-estate professionals — *without* singling individuals out as "mentors." It should read as "these are just real dudes," and that range is what gives the work credibility with the kids.

The alumni / reciprocity loop. **[Emerging intent]** A recurring theme: a program with an open door where people who come through come back and give back — "you're gone doing your thing, but you're never forgotten here." The group is genuinely drawn to this, but it's too early to formalize it into an initiative or attach action items. It's something to monitor and let grow opportunistically.

Origin to preserve. **[Narrative]** This grew organically from people coming together to play basketball, with a mentorship energy emerging from that. Worth preserving as origin story — it makes for a compelling narrative and is a useful lens on how the initiative continues to

evolve.

The name. [Firm] Confirmed as **La Familia Community Scholarship**. "La Familia" stays in Spanish throughout. "Community" was added intentionally to signal inclusiveness — the heritage framing is present, but the circle is open to everyone regardless of background.

3. Firm decisions (carry into the canonical artifacts)

These are settled decisions from the session — the items that should be reflected as canonical in the strategy doc, one-pager, and deck.

Funding model – Individual donor cap: **\$1,000** for the founding year. – **One-time donations only** — no recurring mechanism, contracts, or pledges at this time. – Baseline target: **~\$2,500** — a target to work toward, not a cap. This is a current working figure and should be **revisited once initiative budgets are set** (see action items). – Larger commitments would trigger added rigor around legal and tax structure. – (No fixed default per-donor ask is being set at this time.)

Scholarship disbursement — three channels, age-gated – **Cash to the parent** (in the child's name) for anyone **under 18** / not yet graduated high school, including minors going on trips or to summer programs. Mario is not comfortable putting cash directly in a minor's hands. – **Cash to the student** for those **18+ and in college** — e.g., ~\$500 toward books, gear, or college expenses, used at their discretion. – **Direct payment to a vendor** for any initiative (college visits, trips, books). For college visits specifically, no cash goes to the child; the vendor is paid or program funds are used. – **Per-kid amounts are left open** to the discretion of Mario *and the committee*, based on need, age, and goal. Not a fixed or even split this term.

Donor experience — "close the loop" – Keep a **ledger** of who gave and how much, plus a **separate record of what the kids did** with the support. – Each donor receives a **receipt** that states the donation amount, expresses gratitude, and includes a disclaimer that the contribution is made with the understanding that there is **no tax deduction/exemption at this time**. This is an acknowledgment, not a tax document. – **Personal acknowledgment + midsummer update + post-summer recap**. – The donor experience is about feeling part of something good — human and relational, not bureaucratic. – Optionally, give a supported kid the chance to send a quick positive "thank you / what's up" — framed as receptivity, never pressure.

Decision-making – Material decisions are made through **equal committee-member support** (not specifying majority vs. unanimous at this point). – **Mario Ramos — Chairperson**: champions the initiative, with strong commitment from the committee members. – **Pedro Rosa — Facilitator**: provides operational, technology, and project-management support.

Operating model (founding year) – **Friends-and-family**, operating informally. – Formalization this year is limited to **instantiating an LLC and opening a bank account under the LLC**. No further legal/tax structure is expected for the founding year; anything beyond that is deferred.

4. Summer 2026 execution plan

Three initiatives were locked for the founding summer:

1. **A game** — a group outing to a game together (Mario has ~10 tickets in hand; a fire/police game via Elliott was mentioned as an option).
2. **A summer trip** — a shared experience to bond the group and expose them to something new (the Dells-style trip and "first-experience" trips like the Wisconsin cave / powwow were the models referenced).
3. **College visits** — programmatic, for underclassmen / rising juniors and seniors and summer-program kids (e.g., a University of Illinois tour).

Timing: Game and college visits targeted for **June / early July**; the trip can land anytime over the summer. Specific dates are TBD but should be scoped soon so donors have concrete answers.

Budget: A range of figures was discussed but nothing was settled, so no dollar amounts are recorded here. **Determining the overall budget (and per-initiative budgets) is an action item**, and that figure should be used to revisit the ~\$2,500 baseline target.

5. Operating model & payment approach

- **Founding-year structure**: an LLC with a bank account under the LLC (Chase).
- **Donations — phased**:

- **Phase 1 (near term):** donors are directed to contact a committee member, who provides the details to send a **Zelle** payment to the LLC's Chase account; the committee follows up with a receipt. Donors can also Zelle the Chase account directly.
- **Phase 2: a Stripe-connected donation button** / online payment added to the site.
- All contributions carry the **friends-and-family disclaimer**, and receipts carry the no-tax-deduction note (per Section 3).
- **Park district sensitivity:** avoid implying Chicago Park District endorsement or liability in any materials — keep references to the organization, not the park district.

Note: the LLC, bank account, payment-processor setup, and any tax/legal disclaimers are for the committee to execute with the appropriate professionals. This synthesis documents the agreed approach, not legal or financial advice.

6. Deliverables

Canonical artifacts — always available, always evolving (the single source of truth). These should always reflect the current state of operations, vision, mission, activities, and tactics: 1. **One-page write-up** — audience-neutral; vision, mission, and initiatives. Delivered near-term as an **HTML page** accessible to committee members. 2. **Committee PowerPoint** — concise and attractive; surfaces vision, mission, and initiatives up front (encompassing the one-pager concisely), with details that always reflect current state. Delivered near-term as an **HTML page**. 3. **Full strategy & game plan** — the canonical operational document (vision, mission, funding model, donor experience, roles and alignment, near-term milestones, scholarship-application placeholder, open questions). Always reflects current state.

Update process for the canonical artifacts – **Long-term vision:** artifacts stored in **GitHub** and accessible to committee members. A member interacts with an **AI agent** via chat/text — the agent surfaces information from the canonical artifacts and can take member-provided updates. Updates land in a **staged state** and require **approval by Mario (Chairperson) and Pedro (Facilitator)** before becoming canonical. Likely a few weeks to stand up. – **Near-term interim:** the HTML one-pager and committee deck are available to members; any strategy updates are **routed to Mario and Pedro**, with **Pedro (Facilitator) owning the updates** to the canonical artifacts.

Member-facing access – A **member-facing HTML hub page** linking to all applicable pages (one-pager, deck, etc.).

Supporting artifacts (near-term deliverables) – **Lead-capture / public donation site** (separate from the member hub). Version 1 is a simple landing page describing the organization with instructions to contact a committee member to donate (Zelle, per Section 5); it also serves as the **warm-lead capture** mechanism. Version 2 adds the Stripe-connected donation button. This is where pledged "warm leads" get formally captured (name, contact, amount). – **Donor ask** — a short (~60-second) ask plus acknowledgment/sign-off language; likely delivered as an HTML sheet.

Scholarship application (placeholder content for now). Mario has a rough template. It should capture name, address, parents, phone, school, and anticipated graduation date on one page; plus a separate handwritten page of educational/career goals and activities/community involvement; plus a copy of recent grades — **handwritten and signed by the student**. It functions as the student's commitment/accountability. Rough timeline: distribute ~mid-May, allow 3–4 weeks (school ends ~June 5), target return by ~**June 30**.

Deferred / on-demand. Student intake form and travel-permission forms will be created as required.

7. Action items & next steps

- **Lock the three initiatives** (game, trip, college visit) on the calendar. — *Mario*
- **Determine the overall budget** (and per-initiative budgets), then **revisit the ~\$2,500 baseline target** against it. — *Mario / committee*
- **Iterate the three canonical artifacts** (one-pager → deck → strategy), keeping the scholarship-application placeholder. — *Pedro (Facilitator) + working session*
- **Stand up near-term member access:** HTML one-pager, committee deck, and member-facing hub page; route strategy updates to Mario + Pedro, with Pedro owning the updates (interim before the GitHub / AI-agent staging workflow).
- **Build the lead-capture / public donation site (Version 1)** and start capturing pledged donors (name, contact, amount).
- **Draft the scholarship application** from Mario's template; set the return deadline (~June 30).
- **Set up the payment path:** instantiate the LLC and open the LLC bank account (Chase); stand up Phase 1 donations via **Zelle** to the Chase account with committee follow-up receipts; plan Phase 2 (Stripe-connected button). Include the friends-and-family / no-tax-deduction disclaimer.
- **Run the fundraising ask** and aim to **close by ~June 20** so funds are in hand for the summer.

- **Next working session: June 9** — bring in / present to founding members (Rob, Munchie, Ray) for the first time.
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8. Open questions & deferred items

Emerging intents the committee will monitor (no action attached yet): – **Value internalization** — Mario's emerging "next desire": how to help the young men genuinely *see and internalize* the value of what's invested in them — receptivity and accountability, never pressure. Documented as a real theme; whether it becomes a literal initiative or simply something the committee watches and lets evolve is to be determined. – **The "family not philanthropy" sentiment** and the **alumni / reciprocity loop** (see Sections 1 and 2) — directions the committee is drawn to, monitored and allowed to evolve opportunistically.

Deferred to a future session: – Further **legal formalization** (beyond the LLC + bank account) and **expanded marketing infrastructure**. *(Note: "session" itself still needs to be defined — the current set of activities may comprise the first session, after which we figure out what's next.)*

Kept on the future list (deferred, not now): – A possible **AI mentor tool** (something a kid could turn to in a tough moment) — raised as a big-vision idea, explicitly not something to build now.

9. Guiding principles reaffirmed

- **Don't over-engineer; avoid analysis paralysis.** A few things done well go far. Stay organic.
- **Frame at the intent level first**, then let near-term tactics follow.
- **Stay true to the impact the founding committee members want.** Wide-scale opportunities will come; let others carry those. The founding committee members shouldn't feel pressured to do it all.
- **Maintain a single source of truth.** All artifacts and decisions derive from one canonical strategy/vision document; iterate that rather than scattering competing versions.
- **The initiative belongs to the committee collectively** — championed by Mario as Chairperson, with strong commitment from the committee.